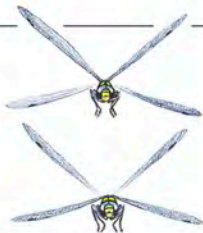




DRAGONFLIES

Many insects are good fliers, but dragonflies are truly the champions of flight. Millions of years ago, enormous dragonflies patrolled the skies. Even today's finger-length dragonflies are quite large compared to other insects. Once dragonflies have emerged from their water-based nymph stage, they take to the air, flying at speeds of up to 34 miles (54 kilometers) per hour.

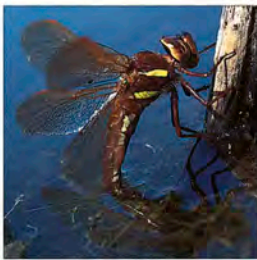


Wing power

Dragonflies have strong muscles which control the base of the wings. In flight, the wings look like a rapidly changing X shape.

Mating dragonflies

Brightly colored male dragonflies cling to the necks of females with their tails.



Each pair of clear, veined wings can beat separately. This means that dragonflies can hover.



Dragonflies have excellent eyesight. They have two huge compound eyes. Each eye can have up to 30,000 lenses.

Laying eggs

When the female is ready to lay her eggs, she dips her abdomen into the water. The eggs sink below the surface where they hatch as wingless nymphs that live underwater for up to four years.

Breaking out

When the nymph is fully developed, it climbs out of the water and clings to a plant stem where it undergoes a spectacular change. The nymph's skin cracks open at the back and an adult dragonfly slowly pulls itself free.



The bristles on the dragonfly's front legs help it to trap prey in the air.

